

Software Licenses

Learning Objectives

- Understand what a software license is
- Differentiate between free and paid software
- Recognize the importance of respecting software licenses

Engage (5-7 minutes)

Think of renting a house—you get permission to live there but do not own it. A software license is like a rental agreement—it gives you permission to use software under certain rules. Today we learn about the legal and ethical side of using software.

Explore (10-12 minutes)

Look at the terms and conditions when you open a program. Find the “About” section in a program to see its license type. Compare free software like Scratch with paid software like MS Office. Discuss what “free” really means in terms of software.

Explain (10-12 minutes)

A software license is a legal agreement that tells you how you can use software. Free and open-source software lets anyone use, study, and share it. Proprietary software requires payment and restricts copying. Freeware is free to use but not open-source. Always respect license terms to use software legally.

Elaborate (8-10 minutes)

Create a chart comparing different license types with examples. Discuss why creators charge for software—it takes time and skill to make. Think about open-source projects like Wikipedia and Scratch that are free. Write three rules for being a responsible software user.

Evaluate (5-8 minutes)

Exit ticket: What is a software license? Name the difference between free software and paid software. Why is it wrong to copy paid software without permission? Give an example of free software you use.